

JesusOnline Equip

Ministry Resources Hub

Rebuke: 10, Flattery: 0

A free resource from JesusOnline Ministries.

Read or share online: app.jesonline.com/post/22220-019-rebuke-10-flattery-0

JesusOnline Equip · Ministry Resources Hub · equip.jesonline.com

Free media and discipleship resources for pastors, leaders, and growing disciples.

Rebuke: 10, Flattery: 0

Wounds from a friend can be trusted, but an enemy multiplies kisses. (Proverbs 27:6)

He who rebukes a man will in the end gain more favor than he who has a flattering tongue. (Proverbs 28:23)

Do not rebuke a mocker or he will hate you; rebuke a wise man and he will love you. (Proverbs 9:8)

Hollywood—and much of the entertainment industry—has a really seductive cultural practice. I call it “vain praise.” It sounds like this: “Hey, baby, you have what it takes to be a star.” “Oh, dahling, you look gorrrgeous.” “With your looks/body/talent, you’ll be a household name in no time.”

I attended a Hollywood funeral a few years ago and listened to the flattering palaver of about a dozen of the media elite, some of whom I knew really couldn’t stand the deceased. Even in death (especially in death?), they couldn’t tell the truth.

God explains a fascinating dynamic in the writings of King Solomon about the benefits of rebuke and the folly of flattery. The concept isn’t abstruse. It is based on the value of telling other people the truth (graciously) and not worrying about their feelings or the possible backlash. Scriptures actually feature well-motivated rebuke as essential to true friendship!

You read it above: “The wounds of a friend can be trusted.”

Principle: True friends will love you enough to scrub you down with truth, even when they know it stings. Your enemies will lather you up with the soft soap of what they think you want to hear.

This principle of “rebuke-willingness” is so thoroughly endorsed by King Solomon that he touts it as a long-term strategy to gain favor. Note in the second verse cited above, the emphasis is on the long term. In the short-term, loving rebuke can have

really adverse effects, because the wisdom of the rebuke hasn't had a chance to "play out" to its consequences.

When the wisdom of a rebuke has kept the friend from suffering the consequences of a wrong path, a destructive habit, or serious character weakness, he will be filled with gratitude and embrace you.

Principle: A relationship based on open truth is true friendship; one built on flattery is a con game.

Solomon does have one caveat in the rebuke principle. That is discerning whether the one needing the rebuke qualifies as a "fool" one who despises wisdom and instruction. In such a case, he cautions us not to give unwanted counsel, direction, correction, or rebuke, because, "He who rebukes a fool invites abuse" (Proverbs 9:7).

Principle: A loving rebuke requires running your hand along the wall of another's soul and feeling for a crack to put the truth in; if there's no crack, don't bother throwing it at the wall.

So a phrase to memorize when confronted with rebuke or constructive criticism is, "Thank you for the helpful suggestion." It will help you, if you let God use it in your life!

[from "[*Wisdom for the Trenches*](#)" by Dr. Larry W. Poland]

Thank you for downloading this free resource!

We're grateful you've taken this step in your spiritual journey. Your growth in Christ encourages us, and we pray this has been a blessing—strengthening your faith, deepening your understanding of God's Word, and equipping you to live for His glory.

Share Your Thoughts

Your feedback helps us improve future resources and encourages others:

Leave a Review or Send Us a Note — If you found this helpful, please consider leaving a short review. Your honest words make a big difference! We love hearing how God is using these materials in your life.

Share Your Story → equip.jesonline.com/reviews/share

Discover More Free Resources

Continue growing in your walk with Jesus. Here are additional tools from the JO EQUIP library and JesusOnline Ministries:

- **Explore the Free Books** → equip.jesonline.com/books
- **Download the Free JO App** — Your personal discipleship hub with the NET Bible, daily devotions, interactive studies, prayer tools, more books, and videos. [Download for Android](#) · [Download for iOS](#) · Explore in browser → app.jesonline.com
- **Watch Video Playlists** → equip.jesonline.com/playlists
- **Visit JesusOnline Ministries** — For more about this ministry and global outreach: jesonlineministries.org

Would you like to help others? Share this resource (or the download link) with friends, your small group, or your church. Every copy planted can bear eternal fruit!

Thank you again for partnering with us in the Great Commission. May the Lord continue to fill you with joy, peace, and purpose as you walk with Him.

In Christ,

The JesusOnline Ministries Team

Apologetics • Evangelism • Discipleship • Equipping